

Sammy Abdella

Professor Emily M. Suazo

ENGLGS1010_816_2025_3 - UNIVERSITY WRITING

26 September 2025

Accept with Love, Tell the Truth

“It is the innocence which constitutes the crime.” James Baldwin starts his 1962 letter as an intimate address to his little nephew, but quickly turns it into a public reckoning (Baldwin). Through repetition, pronoun shifts, and present- tense urgency, Baldwin makes “acceptance with love” a form of truth telling and accountability rather than surrender.

Baldwin's letter, which starts with a really interesting sentence, “I have begun this letter five times and torn it up five times”, sounds less like he's having writer's block and more like he's contemplating telling the harsh truth to a loved one (Baldwin). The repetitions (“five times... five times”) gives us a rough idea about the drafts we never got to see. It conveys doubt, which contrasts with the tone of certainty that's present throughout the letter.

The letter contains even more repetitions, such as the term "innocence", which is repeated a lot. He's not necessarily calling white Americans pure. It's not about praise but more like a diagnosis. He also repeats the word "accept" but he inverses the roles of who should accept whom. He said that there's no reason his nephew should "become like a white man" . However, that doesn't mean he shouldn't accept them. He said “You must accept them and accept them with love.” (Baldwin).

The way he talks about white Americans is steady. He calls them "innocent and well meaning" but also says that they're "trapped in a history which they do not understand." (Baldwin) This shifts the blame from "bad apples" to the entity that's the American system. Ultimately, he's teaching his nephew, along with the readership, that truth is not hidden under innocence.

In order to make his message more appealing to both his nephew and the broader readership, the letter repeats the "I" and "you," but it often turns to "they" and "we." "You" makes the guidance personal. "They" makes the charge public. "We" unites. When Baldwin writes that "they have destroyed and are destroying" lives, the present tense carries a lot of weight (Baldwin). It means that harm is active. It means that memory isn't enough and that awareness is really needed right now. He's teaching his nephew about history, along with the readership, and giving advice about the future.

Baldwin also educates his audience by using active voice as a rhetorical device. He doesn't say "wrong was done." but he actually points out who does it. He's teaching his nephew and the audience to speak with the same clarity and denounce bad actions in a society that promotes racist rhetoric. He goes on describing this society "You were born where you were born... because you were black and for no other reason." (Baldwin) He's exposing how awful society can be depending on the color of someone's skin. That sentence is flat on purpose. No hedges. It gives a lot of room for the reader to formulate their own opinions about that raw perspective. After that blunt sentence, Baldwin lists how bad society is when it comes to limiting the ability of the black community: where you could live, where you could go, what you could do.

However, he goes on to give his nephew some hope: “there is really no limit to where you can go.” (Baldwin) The order of the sentences matters. First there’s the reality check, then comes the hopeful message.

He also redefines “integration.” He rejects the idea that the nephew must “become like white men.” He repeats “accept,” but he flips it. “You must accept them.” He's teaching his nephew accountability. He doesn't want him to rely on white people to do the right thing, he wants him to take action instead, since white people can't be trusted.

Baldwin’s tone toward white Americans is firm without being cruel. He calls them “innocent and well meaning,” and then he shows why that innocence is a really big problem. (Baldwin) He says they are “trapped in a history.” The trap image shifts attention from a few bad actors to a system that trains people not to know. But this isn’t a pass. It's not an excuse that he's giving them. If the trap is built, it means that some people built it. He's again teaching him responsibility by using them as an example. The trap exists, a lot of people were forced into it by the system who created it, and he needs to fight it. In a hopeful message, Baldwin calls Black presence a “fixed star” and an “immovable pillar.” When that star moves, he says, “heaven and earth are shaken.” (Baldwin)

With the hopeful messages throughout the letter comes a lot of advice in short commands: “Please try to remember.” “Please try to be clear.” The politeness of “please” doesn't weaken them. A letter isn’t a speech. It feels like a conversation, even if only one person is speaking. That imagined back and forth makes the commands feel like he's addressing his nephew in a

caring way, but he's also giving advice to a broader audience who could use the advice, people who might not have the privilege of receiving the same guidance. In a system that's specifically designed to misguide African Americans, he's taking it upon himself to share his knowledge, and make his voice heard.

Baldwin's letter has many layers to it, where even its punctuation carries meaning. Baldwin's commas and periods land exactly where breath would land if the letter was spoken. Baldwin intended for the letter to cater to both his nephew but also many other demographics who need to hear his message and take his advice. Throughout the letter, Baldwin shows that love and truth can sit in the same sentence: remember where you come from, don't accept someone else's idea of you, refuse innocence as an alibi, accept people with love, push them toward reality.

The letter may sound blunt sometimes, however, reality was and is still blunt towards minorities in America, and this letter is truthful. It mirrors his love through his raw commentary on the situation in the country and the choices that would dictate his nephew's future, along with the future of people his generation, which together make up the future of the Black community in America. Ultimately, Baldwin is advising his community in a letter that's technically intended for his nephew.

Works Cited

Baldwin, James. "A Letter to My Nephew." *The Progressive*, 1 Dec. 1962, progressive.org/magazine/letter-nephew/. Accessed 27 Sept. 2025.